MSc in Business Information Systems Regulation for Master Thesis

1 Scope

This regulation applies to the Master of Science in Business Information Systems (MSc BIS) in the School of Business of the FHNW University of Applied Sciences and Arts Northwestern Switzerland.

For master theses written as part of the double degree programmes a separate regulation applies.

2 Position in the Curriculum

The Master Thesis is a compulsory module of the studies for the Master of Science in Business Information Systems.

2.1 Time Frame

The master thesis is usually done in the final two semesters. It consists of two phases.

1. In the first phase, the student writes a research proposal. The corresponding module is named “Master Thesis Proposal”.
2. In the second phase, the student conducts the research as described in the proposal and writes the final master thesis report. The module of this second phase is named "Master Thesis".

2.2 Admission

Attendance and successfully passing of the module “Research Methods in Information Systems” is a prerequisite for the “Master Thesis Proposal”. Successfully passing the “Master Thesis Proposal” is a prerequisite for the "Master Thesis".

2.3 Editing

The master thesis is essentially an individual project. In exceptional cases, i.e. if the subject cannot reasonably be reduced, it may be performed by a team of two. In this case, both students must have separate research objectives. Applications for a team of two have to be sent to the head of programme, who has to approve it.

3 Aim and Purpose of the Master Thesis

The master thesis is of central importance to Master's award during which the student is expected to bring together aspects of learning from previous modules as well as using this learning as the basis for planning, conducting and writing up a research-based project.

4 Topics for the Master Thesis

4.1 Requirements for the Topic

There are two types of master thesis

- Application-oriented Research: The master thesis has to deal with a topic in the area of business information systems which is of practical importance for enterprises. The topic has to fulfil the following criteria:
    - It generates new knowledge in the area of business information systems,
    - It provides a concrete business value,
    - It requires the application of research methods.

  The master thesis can be written in cooperation with a company located in Switzerland or all over the word. However, the solution of a specific problem for a company without a generalizable solution or concept does not fulfil the requirements of a master thesis.
- New Business: The objective is to develop an innovative business idea based on information, information systems or information technology. The topic has to fulfil the following criteria:
    - It generates an innovation that satisfies customer needs and differentiates from current approaches,
    - it requires the application of research methods.

4.2 Topic Selection

4.2.1 Topic by Researchers of FHNW

Lecturers and researchers of FHNW can propose topics for master theses. The topics generally relate to research areas the institutes or individual researchers are involved in. The procedure is as follows:

1. The topic is described by the potential supervisor and added to the list of master thesis topics that are made available to the students.
2. Students contact the mentioned supervisor of the topic they are interested in. Together they can adapt the topic if required.
3. Students and supervisors agree on the master thesis topic as described in Section 4.3.

4.2.2 Topic by Students

It is possible for students to propose their own topics. The procedure is as follows:

1. The student proposes the topic to a potential supervisor. The supervisor can be the lecturer of the corresponding subject or a researcher of FHNW. If the potential supervisor agrees to supervise, student and supervisor together precise or adapt the topic if required.
2. If the supervisor considers that the topic is suitable, then student and supervisor agree on the master thesis topic as described in Section 4.3.

4.3 Agreement on Master Thesis

Students and supervisor(s) must officially agree on a master thesis topic. The agreement determines the topic and deadlines of the thesis and it clarifies the roles of student and supervisor(s). The procedure is as follows:

1. The student fills the online form "Agreement on Master Thesis", ticks the "I agree" checkbox and submits the form.
2. The supervisor approves the agreement by ticking the "I agree" checkbox and submitting the form.

The Agreement on the Master Thesis **is binding**.

5 Master Thesis Proposal

5.1 Objective and Result of the Master Thesis Proposal

In the Master Thesis Proposal module the students compile a proposal for their master thesis. During this module, the students review the literature to identify the research problem, specify their thesis statement and research questions and determine the research methodology which is appropriate to do the research.

The result of the master thesis proposal is a report which should consist of at least the following elements:

- Introduction & Problem Description
- Thesis Statement and Research Questions
- Literature Review
- Research Design
- References and Appendices

5.2 Master Thesis Seminar

The Master Thesis Seminar consists of a lecture on how to write a master thesis. It is part of Master Thesis Proposal module. Attendance is mandatory.

6 Master Thesis – Report and Defence

The result of the master thesis consists of a report and the defence.

6.1 Report

The report should be addressed to an expert third person, who should be able to understand all the essential aspects of it without commentary.

The quality of the work is not directly proportional to the size of the report. The challenge is to include all important information, to omit unimportant aspects and also to avoid unnecessary repetition. For a thesis of this scope, this generally means approx. 15’000 – 25’000 words.

6.1.1 Authenticity

When submitting the report, students must confirm in writing that the work was performed autonomously using only the sources, aids and assistance stated in the report and that quotes are readily identifiable as such.

6.1.2 Language Regulations

The report has to be written in English. Literature and other sources can be in any language. Interviews and/or questionnaires can be made in any language. The analysis and presentation has to be in English.

6.1.3 Layout and Citations

The guidelines for writing of the thesis are described in the document “Academic and Scientific Writing”. FHNW provides a template for the layout of the thesis, but students are free to use their own layout.

6.1.4 Confidentiality

The master thesis report should describe findings of general interest and it is public. If the master thesis is done in cooperation with and/or by order of a company the report can be declared confidential on request of the company. Confidentiality can also be declared for the appendix only. If the research described in the report is based on confidential data, then it is recommended to separate these data into a confidential appendix.

If confidentiality is requested, the company has to provide a proposal for the Non Disclosure Agreement. Confidentiality of the thesis or parts of it has to be approved by the head of programme. The student has to declare which parts are confidential when submitting the thesis report.

6.2 Defence

The defence consists of

- a final presentation of the master thesis of 30 minutes
- a defending discussion of the same duration between the first supervisor, the second supervisor (if applicable), an examiner, lecturers present and the student.

The defence generally takes place about 3 to 4 weeks after hand-in of the written report.

The defence takes place in presence. In justified cases, the head of degree program may approve exceptions. The master thesis coordinator schedules the defences, organises a suitable room and announces the defence.

7 Submission of the Master Thesis Proposal and the Master Thesis

The students must submit their master thesis proposal and master thesis (written report and additional material if available) electronically. A hardcopy submission is not required.

The written report (and additional material if available) must be uploaded in electronic form to the corresponding Moodle course on time (see section 7.1 Submission Deadline).

- The report must be submitted in PDF format.
  File identification/file name: *<StudentSurname>-<StudentFirstName>-<Year>.pdf*
- In case of submitting additional material (data sets, program code, audio files etc.), a ZIP file containing the additional material must be uploaded.
  File identification/file name: *<StudentSurname>-<StudentFirstName>-<Year>.zip*

If the files are too large for submission on Moodle, the student can upload only the thesis on Moodle and upload the additional material on SwitchDrive. In this case, the student has to provide a reference in the thesis appendix.

7.1 Submission Deadline

The submission deadline for the master thesis proposal or master thesis is 21st of December for the autumn semester and 21st of June for the spring semester.

- Submission is possible until 24:00 (local time of FHNW) of the submission deadline. Late submission is not possible.
- The students can submit the written report at any time before the deadline and resubmit updated versions. A resubmission replaces the previous submission – only the latest version is evaluated.

In order not to miss the deadline, students are strongly encouraged to upload pre-versions of the written report at an early stage. Technical problems do not count as an excuse for not submitting in time.

8 Timetable

8.1 Regular Timetable

The master thesis can be written in the autumn or spring semester with corresponding timetables. The important dates are listed in the following tables.

Scheme 1

Spring Semester: Master Thesis Proposal

December - February	Students contact the supervisors and agree on master thesis topic
21 March	Latest date for handing in the agreement form
Beginning of semester	Master Thesis Seminar "How to Write a Master Thesis"
21 June	Deadline for uploading the research proposal to the corresponding Moodle course

Autumn Semester: Master Thesis

June - July	Supervisor accepts research proposal for the master thesis
21 December	Deadline for uploading the final report to the corresponding Moodle course
January	Defences

Scheme 2: Master Thesis in Spring Semester

Autumn Semester: Master Thesis Proposal

July - September	Students contact the supervisors and agree on master thesis topic
21 September	Latest date for handing in the agreement form
Beginning of semester	Master Thesis Seminar "How to Write a Master Thesis"

21 December	Deadline for uploading the research proposal to the corresponding Moodle course

Spring Semester: Master Thesis

December - January	Supervisor accepts research proposal for the master thesis
21 June	Deadline for uploading the final report to the corresponding Moodle course
July	Defences

8.2 Deferral of Master Thesis

In exceptional cases it is possible to have a break of one semester between the master thesis proposal and the master thesis. Deferral requires approval by the head of programme. In this case, a new agreement form with the new deadline has to be submitted.

8.3 Change of Topic or Supervisor for Master Thesis

The master thesis proposal and master thesis are subsequent modules. After the master thesis proposal module was passed successfully, it is possible, in exceptional cases, to change the topic and/or the supervisor for the master thesis. The change has to be approved by the head of programme.

If the topic or supervisor for the master thesis is changed, a new agreement form has to be made between student and supervisor. In this case, the timetable for repetition of master thesis is applicable.

8.4 Repetition of Master Thesis

Failed master thesis proposals must be repeated in the subsequent semester, unless otherwise agreed with the supervisor and head of programme.

Failed master theses can be repeated in the subsequent semester. The student also has the possibility to repeat the master thesis in a later semester.

8.4.1 Repeating the Master Thesis in the Subsequent Semester

Doing the master thesis in the subsequent semester after the failed master thesis, the following timetables are applicable.

Scheme 1: Master Thesis in Autumn Semester

August - September	Students contact the supervisors and agree on master thesis topic
21 September	Latest date for handing in the agreement form
21 February	Deadline for uploading the final report to the corresponding Moodle course
March	Defences

Scheme 2: Master Thesis in Spring Semester

February – March	Students contact the supervisors and agree on master thesis topic

21 March	Latest date for handing in agreement form
21 August	Deadline for uploading the final report to the corresponding Moodle course
September	Defences

8.4.2 Repeating the Master Thesis in a Later Semester

Doing the master thesis in a later semester, gives the student the opportunity to spend more time for doing the research. In this case the following timetables are applicable.

Scheme 1: Master Thesis in Autumn Semester

June - July	Students contact the supervisors and agree on master thesis topic
21 July	Latest date for handing in the agreement form
21 December	Deadline for uploading the final report to the corresponding Moodle course
January	Defences

Scheme 2: Master Thesis in Spring Semester

December - January	Students contact the supervisors and agree on master thesis topic
21 January	Latest date for handing in agreement form
21 June	Deadline for uploading the final report to the corresponding Moodle course
July	Defences

9 Assessment Master Thesis Proposal

The supervising lecturer evaluates the report, records the result on the assessment form and informs the student about the evaluation by submitting the assessment form.

10 Assessment Master Thesis

The master thesis is examined by the supervisor(s) and an additional examiner based on the written report and the defence. A combined assessment form is created.

The supervisor informs the student about the evaluation by sending the assessment form. The written assessment may be supplemented by an oral explanation on the students' request.

11 Roles of Supervisor

The students are supervised by a lecturer or researcher of FHNW. Students can optionally be supervised by two supervisors. At least the first supervisor must own an academic doctorate.

The supervisors assess the master thesis proposal. They are present at the defence and assess the defence and the master thesis jointly together with the examiner.

12 Role of Examiner

An examiner is a subject lecturer or researcher, who is not a supervisor of the same master thesis. The examiner must own an academic doctorate.

The examiner is present at the defence and assesses the defence and the master thesis jointly together with the supervisor(s).

13 Escalation Scenario

Any serious problems concerning the thesis or the relation between the student and the supervisor shall be solved in a dialogue between student and supervisor.

If the problems cannot be solved, the module coordinator shall be involved. If necessary, the head of the programme can be involved as well.

14 Use of the Name and Brand of the FHNW

The student may use the name of the FHNW for written surveys as follows: questionnaires and covering letter from the student should be printed on neutral stationery, a covering letter from the supervising lecturer may be written on the stationery of FHNW.

15 Additional Documents

- Module description Master Thesis Proposal
- Module description Master Thesis
- Agreement Form
- Assessment form Master Thesis Proposal
- Assessment form Master Thesis
- Guideline Academic and Scientific Writing
- Master thesis template (the use is voluntary)

16 Transition Provision

This regulation takes effect in spring semester 2025.